

# APOCALYPSE AND aftermath

## THE BLACK DEATH

In 1347, 12 ships sailing from the Black Sea docked in Sicily, with sailors dead and dying from a fatal plague on board. This plague had already struck the trading nations of the East including China, India, and Persia. Over the next four years, the disease spread across Europe, killing at least one-third of its population in what became known as the Black Death. No subsequent outbreaks were as devastating as that of the 14th century, but plagues would ravage Europe until the 18th century, particularly across its dirty and densely-packed cities.

Many characterized the Black Death as a divine punishment for the sins of the people. Some monastic chroniclers claimed that women in particular were to blame for the plague due to their “immodest” clothing. Thousands of men took to naked self-flagellation as an act of penance for society’s sins, hoping to repel the plague; the whippings were public events, and female onlookers supposedly screamed encouragement and smeared their eyes with the blood that flew through the air, believing that it contained healing properties. Writers were equally quick

### ▼ Dying woman

This detail from the 1411 Toggenburg Bible depicts a woman dying of the Black Death. Female victims were shown naked, just like men, suggesting that the plague stripped them of any need for modesty.



### ▲ Female producers

Even before the plague, women worked alongside their husbands to produce and sell goods. This 14th-century illustration from Lombardy, Italy, shows women making cheese.



“FAIR **LADIES** BREAKFAST  
WITH THEIR **KINFOLK** AND  
THE SAME NIGHT **SUPPED**  
WITH THEIR **ANCESTORS.**”

GIOVANNI BOCCACCIO ON THE BLACK DEATH